

Audit the Google Business Profile and Conversion Tracking First

The two-item onboarding pass Isaac Justesen (PatientPartners) runs on every new local client, before anything else.

OBJECTIVE

Close the two gaps that cost a local business the most visibility per hour spent: an unfinished Google Business Profile and missing or wrong conversion tracking. The first decides whether you appear in the map pack at all. The second tells you whether anything else you do afterwards worked. Neither needs a content strategy, a budget increase or a redesign, and both finish inside a week.

KEY STEPS

1. **Read the Business Profile as a stranger.** Most were filled in once at opening and never touched. Look for what was never finished.
2. **Fix the primary category, add every legitimate secondary.** The highest-leverage field in local SEO, and routinely still set to whatever was picked on day one.
3. **Add the services list.** Often completely empty. Use the words customers use, not internal or clinical terms.
4. **Check claims language against local rules first.** Rules vary by state and province. Comparative claims are commonly prohibited; "specialist" and "expert" are restricted in many healthcare jurisdictions.
5. **Audit conversion tracking end to end.** Forms, calls and bookings should each fire a distinct, correctly named conversion. Seldom set up correctly even where it appears to exist.
6. **Add call tracking specifically.** Form tracking usually exists; call tracking usually does not. For a local business the phone is the primary conversion path.
7. **Measure the answer rate, not just call volume.** Count how many inbound calls actually get picked up in business hours. (*inferred: the problem is stated on tape; no specific method was prescribed.*)
8. **Re-baseline before starting anything else.** With categories, services and tracking correct, take a fresh reading. Everything after is measured against that line.

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- Do not write profile copy before checking the rules. In regulated verticals this is a compliance problem, not a rejected edit.
- Tracking that exists is not tracking that works. A mismatched tag is worse than none: it produces confident wrong decisions.
- Not a one-time task. Categories, services and hours drift. Put it on a recurring review.
- Do not skip to content or ads. Paid traffic into an unmeasurable business burns a small budget fast.
- Do not replace the front desk with AI to fix the answer rate. Isaac was explicit that it is not good enough yet.

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- Do categories and services in one sitting. Roughly thirty minutes, and the highest-value thirty minutes in the engagement.
- Screenshot the profile before changing anything, so you can tie ranking movement to a date.
- Do the tracking audit second, so the re-baseline captures the profile changes too.
- Keep a per-jurisdiction note of restricted language. It compounds in value across clients.
- Where profile and website disagree, fix the profile first. It is the record more likely to be shown directly to a searcher.

WHY IT MATTERS MORE EACH YEAR

Isaac points at a shift from curation to selection. Classic search curated ten links and let the searcher choose; AI-mediated search increasingly picks one answer and hands it over. As that continues, the structured record Google holds about a business carries more weight, and the page the business wrote about itself carries slightly less.